

University of Texas at Dallas
Course Syllabus PA 6315
Summer 2025 – July 7 to August 12, 2025
Evaluating Program and Organizational performance

Professor: Dr. Abraham David Benavides
Class Time: Mondays & Tuesdays 6:00 - 9:45 pm
Class Location: Dallas City Hall L1EN Room E
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Course Description

Program evaluation is essential for designing and operating effective programs in public and nonprofit organizations. It involves the systematic use of scientific methods to obtain and utilize evidence that can assist decision makers to assess and improve their programs. This course will introduce students to program evaluation theory and practice, including discussion about a) the need and logic of evaluations, why do we need it and how do we use it?, b) the design and theory of evaluation practices, c) its implementation and d) how to understand the outcomes and impacts.

Upon successful completion of this course, students should: 1) Become familiar with the concepts, theories, and methods of evaluation research; 2) Describe the purposes and logic of program evaluation; 3) Raise concrete evaluation questions; 4) Apply principles of research design to evaluation questions; 5) Propose an appropriate evaluation plan to assess the implementation and effectiveness of a program; 6) Use evaluation results to propose ideas and strategies to improve program performance.

The most agile organizations can be described as “learning organizations”—continually adapting to new circumstances and information. Formal evaluation plays a pivotal role in helping organizations learn. This course examines the practical aspects of program evaluation within public policy in domestic and international contexts. Emphasis is placed on the design and implementation of small-to medium-scale program evaluations under time and budget constraints using ‘best feasible’ methods. Topics include the types and purposes of evaluation, theory-based evaluation, evaluability and planning, measurement and construct validity, data collection, evaluation design, estimation of program effects, experiments, qualitative and mixed methods, evaluation resistance, building organizational capacity, ethics, cost-effectiveness, and reporting and utilization. The course will be useful to students working in a variety of mission-driven organizations, especially those who currently have, or expect to have in the future, program evaluation responsibilities.

Course Modality

This course is offered as an in-person intensive summer format on Monday and Tuesday night with 4 hour class meetings. Various teaching methods will be used to keep students active including inclass lectures, team work, projects, assignments, questions and answers, instructional videos, guest lectures, etc.

Learning Objectives

- Develop an understanding of the tools for measuring performance and evaluating the impact of a program or policy
- Critically evaluate the tools and strategies related to program evaluation
- Learn to develop meaningful evaluation questions
- Develop program logic models
- Design, collect, and analyze data for use in evaluation work
- Provide valuable insights and recommendations based on evaluation findings
- Gain ability to use evaluations to improve organizational processes

Textbooks and Other Readings and Materials

Wholey, J. S., Hatry, H. P., & Newcomer, K. E. (2015) 4th Edition. *Handbook of Practical Program Evaluation*. John Wiley & Sons.

Other required readings will be available digitally through the eLearning course page.

(Note: Books are available, for free, as an e-book from the UTD library.)

Additionally, readings will be posted on eLearning. These will consist of various academic articles, book chapters, professional reports, case studies, webpages, Ted Talks, and a number of other items. Because of the increased cost of books, my attempt is to lessen this extra expense while at the same time providing excellent content to provide appropriate context for the course.

Citation Style

For your papers, you should use APA style. Also, feel free to use the vast amount of resources on the Internet. Mainly, I expect students to be consistent in regards to formatting, citations, and references. For more information, please refer to the APA style manual.

American Psychological Association. (2009). *Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association*, 6th Edition.

Limitations This course introduces you to a menu of evaluation methods and helps you learn to select appropriate methods based on an evaluation question and available resources. The application of a specific method, such as multivariate analysis or survey design, in a professional

capacity is likely to require other additional training in that specific method. To the extent practical, students with an interest in particular methods are encouraged to incorporate them into their team projects or evaluation proposals.

Course Requirements and Grading:

The course involves lectures, group exercises, case studies, and class discussion. A typical class will include a lecture, student presentations, general discussion of readings, and group work. We often organize into groups to review and discuss a specific case study or a contemporary public management situation for some portion of class time. The instructor challenges students to relate theories to practical situations or to recommend managerial prescriptions.

There are 4 requirements for the course:

1) **Examinations** 40% –There will be two exams. Exams will cover material presented in the assigned texts, supplemental readings and class discussions. Good answers provide purposeful, justifiable and logical arguments, clear definitions for key concepts, and demonstrate knowledge and command of the topic area. In addition, it is very important that answers specifically address the question(s) asked in the exam. The Take Home exams will be administered on July 21 and August 5.

2) **Evaluation Proposal** 20% –The evaluation proposal is an individual assignment but should relate to the subject matter of your team’s project. You will select a published evaluation and rewrite it in the form of a 1,000 –1,500 word proposal (3 pages) based on publicly available information.

Select and read a published evaluation. This evaluation should relate to the subject area of your team case project. By selecting a case in that subject area, it helps build knowledge within your team about how that type of evaluation is conducted. The evaluation on which you base your proposal can be in the form of a research report (gray literature, such as from a think tank or consultancy) or a peer-reviewed journal article. For best results, base your proposal on a document that has evaluation as its sole or primary purpose and includes a thoroughly documented methods section. You are encouraged to consult with the instructor to confirm you have chosen a suitable document on which to base your proposal.

Write your evaluation proposal through a process like “reverse engineering.” That is, you will mentally go back in time to before this evaluation was conducted and write a proposal to carry out the evaluation described in the publication. Example: If they report that they conducted a randomized controlled trial with 50 participants, you will propose to conduct a randomized controlled trial with 50 participants. Your proposal should not include any information about the results of the evaluation.

Prepare the executive summary after writing the rest of the proposal. Summarize the key points from the other parts of the proposal. An executive summary is not an introduction and should not introduce any information not found elsewhere in the proposal. The idea behind an executive

summary is that it should be able to take the place of the document if the executive is very pressed for time. An executive summary is typically about 10% of the length of the document. Manage expectations. It might be more accurate to describe this assignment as a draft or outline of an evaluation proposal rather than a true proposal. You are not expected to carry out any data collection or analysis. Research and sources cited probably do not need to go beyond the published evaluation and the organization's website. You are required to cite the evaluation on which you base your proposal and any other sources used.

Submit your completed proposal through Blackboard

3) Logic Model 15% Understanding a program's theory and being able to represent it in a logic model is a conventional starting point in program evaluation. Complete a logic model for any program you are familiar with and respond to the questions below. Any structure for the logic model can be used, but it should include program processes and expected outcomes.

Remember, a logic model is a visual or graphic illustration or representation that outlines how a program or initiative is expected to achieve its intended outcomes. It essentially maps out the relationships between resources, activities, and the anticipated changes or results. It's a tool used to clarify the "how" and "why" of a program's design and implementation, helping to identify what needs to be done and what success looks like. Logic models clearly and concisely show how interventions affect behavior and achieve a goal. Additionally, a logic model contains four components: inputs, activities, outputs, and outcomes. Inputs: What the organization invests in the program. (Examples: money, staff, volunteers, time, equipment, materials, technology, partners, etc.) Basically, a logic model is a systematic and visual way to present and share your understanding of the relationships among the resources you have to operate your program, the activities you plan to do, and the changes or results you hope to achieve.

As soon as you have identified a program to evaluate, you can begin working on this assignment. To accompany your logic model, provide a 3 page narrative that answers the questions listed below.

- What are the goals and objectives of the program you will evaluate?
- Whom is the program designed to serve? Include as much demographic detail as possible (age, gender, ethnicity, etc.) for each group impacted by the program (e.g., students, parents, clients, etc.). Give your best estimate if precise demographic information is not available.
- What are the means through which program goals and objectives are expected to be met In other words, what activities does the program utilize to serve its clientele?
- What data/records currently exist relative to goals, objectives, and activities of this program?

4) Program Evaluation Team Project Report & Presentation 20% – In teams of approximately 3, you will develop a report that poses a program evaluation decision problem and present your case to the class. Your case must feature real events, I would suggest doing a proposed program evaluation on a city agency.

Evaluation Protocol

In a total of 10 pages (not counting references/appendices), synthesize your logic model for the program you intend to study and data collection instrument into the following sections, addressing these questions:

- **Evaluation Framework:** What theoretical framework/orientation has guided your program evaluation? How is this framework/orientation well-suited to the program you have evaluated? Explicitly compare it to other options.
- **Stakeholders:** Who are your stakeholders and the readers of your evaluation report? What are their needs and expectations? How do you intend for them to use your evaluation report? What makes the evaluation framework you have chosen well-suited to meet their needs?
- **Existing Program Data:** What data have you utilized in your evaluation? How have you gained access to that data? What form was the data in when you received them? What are the weaknesses of these data?
- **Data Collection:** What, if any, additional data have you collected for your evaluation? How have you collected that data? Include any materials (e.g., surveys, tests, interview questions, observation protocols) that you have used. How did you gain permission and ensure cooperation for data collection?
- **Data Analysis:** How did you analyze your data? How do the results of each analysis relate to specific program goals, objectives, and activities?
- **Recommendations:** Based on your findings, what choices will the stakeholders have to initiate change? What are your recommendations (program should contract, expand, add, delete, maybe even terminate if certain conditions are found)? Where in the logic model is the focal point of your recommendations? For example, are more resources/inputs needed? Do activities need to be adjusted? Are the outcomes realistic? Were there sufficient data /records to conduct evaluation?

Evaluation Briefing

Each group will develop a short, professional presentation designed to convey and sell the proposed protocol to stakeholders. Consider how to briefly, clearly, and convincingly convey the 3-5 most important things stakeholders will learn from your results and the potential choices they may be able to make based on the empirical data. This approximately 15-minute presentation will be given in class.

5) Class Exercises and participation 20% – Throughout the semester, various in class exercises will be distributed. The main purposes of these assignments are to help you summarize the readings, think critically, engage and participate in the class discussions. Assignments will be turned in online during class. Most of the students are active learners and learn best when they can actively engage and discuss the material. The more you participate, the more engaging and interesting the class will be. Your opinions and experiences matter so please share with the class.

Students who pose questions and participate in the discussion sharpen their public presentation skills and learn to think in a clear and critical manner in real time. Students benefit from hearing the discussion and questions of other students. Multiple absences from class will affect this portion of the grade.

Course Grading

- A: 90-100% (Outstanding, excellent work. The student performs well above the minimum criteria).
- B: 80-89% (Good, impressive work. The student performs above the minimum criteria).
- C: 70-79% (Solid, college-level work. The student meets the criteria of the assignment).
- D: 60-69% (Below average work. The student fails to meet the minimum criteria).
- F: 59 and below (sub-par work. The student fails to complete the assignment).

Course Assignments

Activity	Percentage of Final Grade	Due Dates
Logic Model	15 Percent	July 15
Midterm Examination	20 Percent	July 21
Evaluation Proposal	15 Percent	July 29
Final Examination	20 Percent	August 5
Program Evaluation Project Presentations	20 Percent	August 11 and August 12
Class Exercises and Participation	10 Percent	Various Dates

Course Expectations

General expectations

Students are expected to complete all required readings prior to class time, take some notes on the lectures and presentations, participate in class discussions and complete the written assignments and examinations. Case study materials will be either posted on eLearning in advance or passed out in class. The instructor is strongly committed to maintaining a positive learning environment based on open communication, mutual respect, and non-discrimination.

Please respect your instructor and fellow students. Our university does not discriminate on the basis of race, gender, age, disability, veteran status, religion, sexual orientation, color, or national origin. Any suggestions as to how to further such an environment will be appreciated and given serious consideration.

Acceptable Student Behavior:

Student behavior that interferes with an instructor's ability to conduct a class or other students' opportunity to learn is unacceptable and disruptive and will not be tolerated in any instructional

forum at UTD. Students engaging in unacceptable behavior will be directed to leave the classroom and the instructor may refer the student to the Dean of Students to consider whether the student's conduct violated the Code of Student Conduct. The university's expectations for student conduct apply to all instructional forums, including university and electronic classroom, labs, discussion groups, field trips, etc.

Policy on Cell Phone and Laptop in the Classroom

Students are allowed to take notes on personal laptop computers to enhance the learning process, but they should not activate their internet browsers during class or use computers for nonacademic purposes (as this diverts attention from the lecture/discussion for both the student using it and others nearby). Please keep your cell phones on silent mode for the duration of our class period.

Course Schedule, Detail

The descriptions and timelines contained in this syllabus are subject to change at the discretion of the Professor.

Monday July 7 – Evaluation Planning & Design

Introduction to the Course and Historical Context for Program Evaluation

Student Introductions

Chapter 1. Planning and Designing Useful Evaluations 7

Chapter 2 Analyzing and Engaging Stakeholders 36

Tuesday July 8 – Logic Models In Evaluations

Chapter 3 Using Logic Models 62

Chapter 4 Exploratory Evaluation 88

Monday July 14 – Performance Measurement

Chapter 5 Performance Measurement 108

Chapter 6 Comparison Group Designs 137

Tuesday July 15 – Evaluation Practices

Chapter 7 Randomized Controlled Trials 158

Chapter 8 Conducting Case Studies 177

Assignment: Logic Model Due

Monday July 21 – Mid-Term Examination

Mid-Term Examination

The exam will be provided 1 week before it is due.

Tuesday July 22 – Evaluation Methods

Chapter 9 Recruitment and Retention of Study Participants 197

Chapter 14 Using Surveys 344

Monday July 28 – Practical Data Collection Procedures

Chapter 17 Collecting Data in the Field 445

Chapter 20 Focus Group Interviewing 506

Tuesday July 29 – Data Analysis

Chapter 22 Qualitative Data Analysis 561

Chapter 25 Meta-Analyses, Systematic Reviews, and Evaluation Syntheses 673

Monday August 4 – Evaluation Challenges

Chapter 30 Use of Evaluation in Government 798

Chapter 31 Evaluation Challenges, Issues, and Trends 816

Tuesday August 5 – Final Examination

Final Examination

The exam will be provided 1 week before it is due.

Monday August 11 – Project Presentations

Student Program Evaluation Project Presentations

Tuesday August 12 – Project Presentations

Student Program Evaluation Project Presentations

Written Evaluation Projects Due

Student Resources

Reporting Sexual Misconduct and Sharing Confidential Information Students considering sharing personal information in email or in person should be aware that all University staff, faculty, teaching assistants/associates, and graduate/research assistants are required by UT Dallas policy to report information about sexual misconduct to the UT Dallas Title IX Coordinator. Per university policy, Sexual Misconduct Policy - [UTDBP3102](#), faculty have been informed that they must identify the student to the UT Dallas Title IX Coordinator. Students who wish to have confidential discussions of incidents related to sexual harassment or sexual misconduct should contact the following confidential resources, including, but not limited to:

1. the Student Counseling Center (972-883-2575 or the 24/7 Crisis Hotline at 972-UTD-TALK or 972-883-8255),
2. a health care provider in the Student Health Center (972-883-2747),
3. a clergyperson (or other legally recognized religious advisor) of their choice, or
4. an off-campus resource (e.g., a rape crisis center, doctor, psychologist).

Students who are sexually assaulted, harassed, or are victims of sexual misconduct, domestic violence, or stalking, are encouraged to directly report these incidents to the Title IX Coordinator by making a [report](#) online or by calling the Title IX Coordinator at 972-883-2306. Students may also contact the [UTD Police Department \(UTDPD\)](#) for emergency assistance; criminal reporting and investigation; information or assistance regarding protective orders or forensic sexual assault exams; or to request a police escort. In case of emergency, call 911. For non-emergency situations, students can reach the UT Dallas Police Department by calling 972-883-2222. For more information about available support and resources, students can visit the [Office of Institutional Compliance \(Support Services & Resources\)](#) webpage.

Pregnancy and Parenting

UT Dallas is committed to providing support and resources for pregnant and parenting students, faculty, and staff in accordance with Title IX, Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act, the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA), the Texas Education Code Section 51.982, and other applicable federal and state laws. Pregnant and parenting students are encouraged to complete the [Pregnant and Parenting Self-Identification Form](#) located on the [Office of Institutional Compliance's website](#). Submitting this form allows for a coordinated University effort to help facilitate support for pregnant and parenting students, such as early registration for parenting students and accommodations for pregnant students. For more information about the services and resources available to pregnant and parenting students, visit the [Pregnant & Parenting Resources page](#) and the [Student Pregnancy and Parenting Nondiscrimination Policy](#).

Nondiscrimination

UT Dallas prohibits all forms of discrimination (including harassment) based on race, color, religion, sex (including pregnancy), sexual orientation, gender identity, gender expression, age, national origin, disability, genetic information, or veteran status. UT Dallas further prohibits all forms of sex-based discrimination (including sex-based harassment). Students who believe they have been discriminated against or harassed in violation of University policy, or who believe that someone else has been discriminated against or harassed, are encouraged to directly report these incidents to the Office of Institution Compliance by making a [report](#) online or by calling the Office of Institution Compliance at 972-883-2306. For more information, see the University's [Nondiscrimination Policy](#) and [Sexual Misconduct Policy](#). For additional information about available support and resources, see the Office of [Institutional Compliance \(Support Services & Resources\)](#) webpage.

Technical Support

If you experience any issues with your UT Dallas account, contact the UT Dallas [Office of Information Technology Help Desk](#) or call 972-883-2911.

UT Dallas provides eLearning technical support 24 hours a day, 7 days a week through [UTD eLearning Helpdesk](#). The services include a toll-free telephone number, 1-866-588-3192, for immediate assistance. Educational Technology Services (eLearning) is available by [email](#) to request services. They also have an online chat service.

Field Trip Policies, Off-Campus Instruction and Course Activities

Off-campus, out-of-state, foreign instruction/travel, and course-related field trip activities are subject to state law and university policies and procedures regarding travel and risk-related activities.

Detailed information regarding this policy, in accordance to *Texas Education Code*, Section 51.950, can be accessed through the [UT Dallas Policy UTDBP3023](#), and the [Travel-Related Risk Risks webpage](#). Additional information is also available from the office of the school dean by telephone, 972-883-6391 or by [email](#).

Student Conduct and Discipline

The University of Texas System [Regents' Rule 50101](#) and UT Dallas have rules and regulations for the orderly and efficient conduct of their business. It is the responsibility of each student and each student organization to be knowledgeable about the rules and regulations which govern student conduct and activities. General information on student conduct and discipline is contained in the Student Complaints Resources within the online [UT Dallas Undergraduate Catalog](#), and the [Graduate Catalog](#).

UT Dallas administers student discipline within the procedures of recognized and established due process. Procedures are defined and described in the ([Student Code of Conduct, UTDSP5003](#)). Copies of these rules and regulations are available to students in the Office of Community Standards and Conduct, where staff members are available to assist students in interpreting the rules and regulations (SSB 4.400, 972-883-6330) and online at [their webpage](#).

A student at the University neither loses their rights nor escapes the responsibilities of citizenship. He or she is expected to obey federal, state, and local laws as well as the Regents' Rules, university regulations, and administrative rules. Students are subject to discipline for violating its standards of conduct whether such conduct takes place on or off campus, or whether civil or criminal penalties are also imposed for such conduct.

Social Media Use

The [Student Code of Conduct](#) includes behaviors conducted via any digital platform. Students may not use any digital platform to seek or provide unauthorized assistance for any assignment done for academic credit. Students may not use any digital platform to impersonate or represent any person other than themselves. Please consult with your instructor regarding authorized assistance.

Academic Integrity

The faculty expects from its students a high-level of responsibility and academic honesty. Because the value of an academic degree depends upon the absolute integrity of the work done by the student for that degree, it is imperative that a student demonstrates a high standard of individual honor in his or her scholastic work. Additional information is provided within their website.

Academic Dishonesty: Academic dishonesty can occur in relation to any type of work submitted for academic credit or as a requirement for a class. It can include individual work or a group project. Academic dishonesty includes plagiarism, cheating, fabrication, and collaboration/collusion. In order to avoid academic dishonesty, it is important for students to fully understand the expectations of their professors. This is best accomplished through asking clarifying questions if an individual does not completely understand the requirements of an assignment.

Additional information related to academic dishonesty and tips on how to avoid dishonesty may be found [on their website](#).

Copyright Notice

It is the policy of UT Dallas to adhere to the requirements of the United States Copyright Law of 1976, as amended, (*Title 17, United States Code*), including ensuring that the restrictions that apply to the reproduction of software are adhered to and that the bounds of copying permissible under the fair use doctrine are not exceeded. Copying, displaying, reproducing, or distributing copyrighted material may infringe upon the copyright owner's rights. Unauthorized distribution of copyrighted material, including unauthorized peer-to-peer file sharing, may subject students to appropriate disciplinary action as well as civil and criminal penalties. Usage of such material is only appropriate when that usage constitutes "fair use" under the Copyright Act. The [fair use exemption](#) has more information. As a UT Dallas student, you are required to follow UT Dallas' copyright policy, [UTDPP1043](#) and the UT System's copyright policy, [UTS107](#).

In accordance with [Regents' Rule 90101, section 6](#), and federal copyright law, a student enrolled in a course owns the intellectual property created by the student in the course.

Email Use

UT Dallas recognizes the value and efficiency of communication between faculty/staff and students through electronic mail. At the same time, email raises some issues concerning security and the identity of each individual in an email exchange. All official student email correspondence will be sent only to a student's UT Dallas email address and UT Dallas will only consider email requests originating from an official UT Dallas student email account. This allows the University to maintain a high degree of confidence in the identity of each individual corresponding via email and the security of the transmitted information. UT Dallas furnishes each student with a free email account that is to be used in all communication with university personnel. The Office of Information Technology provides a method for students to have their UT Dallas mail forwarded to other email accounts. To activate a student UT Dallas computer account and forward email to another account, access [NetId Self-Service Portal](#) to set it up.

Class Attendance

The University's attendance policy requirement is that individual faculty set their course attendance requirements. Regular and punctual class attendance is expected regardless of course modality. Students who fail to attend class regularly are inviting scholastic difficulty. In some courses, instructors may have special attendance requirements; these should be made known to students during the first week of classes.

Class Participation

Regular class participation is expected regardless of course modality. Students who fail to participate in class regularly are inviting scholastic difficulty. A portion of the grade in the course is directly tied to class participation. It also includes students' engagement in group or other activities during class that solicit feedback on homework assignments, readings, and/or materials covered in the lectures and/or labs. Class participation is documented by faculty. Successful class participation is defined as consistently adhering to University requirements, as presented in the syllabus. Failure to comply with these University requirements is a violation of the [Student Code of Conduct - UTSP5003](#).

Military Affiliated Students

At the University of Texas at Dallas, we are committed to supporting our military and veteran students and their spouses and dependents as they pursue their academic goals. Recognizing the unique challenges faced by those who have served, we strive to create a welcoming and supportive environment. Please contact your instructor if you are on active duty, called to serve, or if any aspect of your current or past military service, or your family situation, makes it challenging to meet the course requirements or affects your academic progress. Your instructor is committed to supporting you and will work with you to address any complications.

The Military and Veteran Center ([MVC](#)) offers a range of resources and referrals to campus and community partners, ensuring that our military and veteran students can access the assistance they need. Whether it is academic advising, financial aid, or personal support, the MVC is dedicated to helping our students succeed and thrive in their educational journey.

Credit/No Credit and Pass/Fail Grading Options

Students are encouraged to review the online catalogs regarding Credit/No Credit or Pass/Fail courses. Students should consult their academic advisors to understand what it means for their academic careers before completing the form prior to Census Day.

Undergraduate students: please review the [Credit/No Credit Classes](#) section in the Undergraduate Catalog.

Graduate students: please review the [Pass/Fail Grading](#) section in the Graduate Catalog.

Withdrawal from Class

The administration at UT Dallas has established deadlines for withdrawal from any course.

These dates and times are published in the [Comet Calendar](#) and in the [Academic Calendar](#). It is the student's responsibility to handle withdrawal requirements from any class. In other words, a professor or another instructor cannot drop or withdraw any student unless there is an administrative drop such as the following:

- Not meeting the prerequisites for a specific course
- Not satisfying the academic probationary requirements, resulting in suspension
- An Office of Community Standards and Conduct request
- Not making appropriate tuition and fee payments
- Enrollment is in violation of academic policy
- Not admitted for the term in which they registered

It is the student's responsibility to complete and submit the appropriate forms to the Registrar's Office and ensure that he or she will not receive a final grade of "F" in a course if he or she chooses not to attend the class after being enrolled.

Undergraduate students: please review the [Dropping and Withdrawing](#) section in the catalog.

Graduate students: please review the [Schedule Changes: Dropping, Adding and Withdrawing from Courses](#) section in the catalog.

Student Grievance Procedures

Procedures for student grievances are found in the university policy [UTDSP5005](#). In attempting to resolve any student grievance regarding disputes over grades, application of degree plan, graduation/degree program requirements, and thesis/and dissertation committee, adviser actions and/or decisions, evaluations, and/or other fulfillments of academic responsibility, it is the obligation of the student first to make a serious effort to resolve the matter with the instructor, supervisor, administrator, or committee with whom the grievance originated.

Incomplete Grade Policy

As per university policy, incomplete grades may be given at the discretion of the instructor of record for a course, when a student has completed at least 70% of the required course material but cannot complete all requirements by the end of the semester. An incomplete course grade (grade of 'I') must be completed within the time period specified by the instructor, not to exceed eight (8) weeks from the first day of the subsequent long semester. Upon completion of the required work, the grade of 'I' may be converted into a letter grade (A through F). If the grade of Incomplete is not removed by the end of the specified period, it will automatically be changed to a grade of F. The incomplete grade policy is included in the online UT Dallas [Undergraduate Catalog](#) and the [Graduate Catalog](#).

Accommodations for Students with Disabilities

The University of Texas at Dallas is committed to providing reasonable accommodations for all persons with disabilities. The syllabus is available in alternate formats upon request. If you are seeking classroom accommodations under the Americans with Disabilities Act (2008), you are required to register with the [AccessAbility Resource Center \(ARC\)](#), located in the Administration Building, Suite 2.224. They can be reached by [email](#), calling 972-883-2098, or at their [website](#). To receive academic accommodations for this class, please register and request services by completing the Request for Services form with the proper documentation and meeting with the Director of ARC at the beginning of the semester.

Religious Holy Days

UT Dallas will excuse a student from class or other required activities, including examinations and travel time, for the observance of a religious holy day for a religion whose places of worship are exempt from property tax under Section 11.20, of the *Texas Tax Code*.

Students are encouraged to notify the instructor or activity sponsor as soon as possible regarding the absence, preferably in advance of the assignment.

Excused students will be allowed to take missed exams or complete assignments within a reasonable time after the absence: a period equal to the length of the absence, up to a maximum of one week. A student who notifies the instructor and completes any missed exam or assignment may not be penalized for the absence. A student who fails to complete the exam or assignment within the prescribed period may receive a failing grade for that exam or assignment.

If a student or an instructor disagrees about the nature of the absence [i.e., for the purpose of observing a religious holy day] or if there is similar disagreement about whether the student has been given a reasonable time to complete any missed assignments or examinations, either the student or the instructor may request a ruling from the school's vice or associate dean, who serve as the President's designees for these rules. The vice or associate deans must take into account the legislative intent of *Texas Education Code* 51.911(b), and the student and instructor will abide by the decision of the vice or associate dean.

This information is also included in the online UT Dallas [Undergraduate Catalog](#), and the [Graduate Catalog](#).

Making a False Alarm or Report Involving a Public or Private Institution of a Higher Education

Making a false threat at any Texas higher education institution is considered a State Jail Felony, not a Class A misdemeanor, according to a law passed by the Texas Legislature.

This legislation was enacted in response to several threats in past years at several universities across the U.S. that disrupted classes and prompted evacuation of campus property, even though the reports turned out to be a hoax.

This law relates to the offense of making or causing a false alarm or report involving a public or private institution of higher education. A person commits an offense under Section 42.06, *Texas Penal Code*, if he or she knowingly initiates, communicates or circulates a report of a present, past, or future bombing, fire, offense, or other emergency that he or she knows is false or baseless and that would ordinarily:

1. Cause action by an official or volunteer agency organized to deal with emergencies;
2. Place a person in fear of imminent serious bodily injury; or
3. Prevent or interrupt the occupation of a building, room, place of assembly, place to which the public has access, or aircraft, automobile, or other mode of conveyance.

An individual adjudged guilty of a state jail felony shall be punished by confinement in a state jail for any term of not more than two years or less than 180 days and, in addition to confinement, may be punished by a fine not to exceed \$10,000.

UT Dallas students should be aware that the State of Texas takes these threats seriously, and the legal consequences, which are severe, go beyond anything that the University's disciplinary committee can address.

This information is also included in the online UT Dallas [Undergraduate Catalog](#) and in the [Graduate Catalog](#).

Interactive Campus Map - Locate Severe Weather Shelters, Elevators, and Bathrooms

The interactive [campus map](#) allows users to search for severe weather shelter areas in each building. On the map, click on a building and select "Storm Shelters" from the "Find" drop-down menu. Remember, a severe weather shelter area is usually any interior room without windows, such as a restroom, hallway, conference room, or office. Try to find shelter on the lowest floor of the building and stay away from large auditoriums or gyms. Users can also use the same map to locate elevators and bathrooms.

Academic Support Resources/Resources to Help You Succeed

Please use the following [Academic Support Resources](#) permanent address when referring to this section.

All Students

For help with a research assignment, such as finding journal articles or using a database, try CHAT at [McDermott Library](#).

The [Center for Students in Recovery](#) helps students seeking recovery from substance and alcohol use, eating disorders, and other addictions and compulsive behaviors. They also help students affected by these issues or individuals exploring the impact of addictions or compulsive behaviors within their lives. Their mission is to provide a safe, supportive community to enable students to thrive both socially and academically while living in recovery. They are located in SSB 4.500, on the fourth floor of the Student Services Building. They can be contacted by calling 972-883-7320 or they can be reached by [email](#).

The [Comet Cupboard](#) is a UT Dallas food pantry initiative dedicated to helping students in need. The Comet Cupboard is located in MC 1.604, on the first floor of the McDermott Library, and can be contacted by calling 972-883-6613 or [email](#).

[Comet Cents](#) provides financial literacy to students with the peer-to-peer model. This money management center provides one-on-one appointments and workshops throughout the semester. Comet Cents works to help students improve their financial situation with topics such budgeting, credit card debit, investing and other personal finance areas.

[Intercultural Programs](#) provides a host of transition programs for international students and intercultural competency trainings for all students. They are located in SSB 3.6, on the third floor of the Student Services Building. Their phone number is 972-883-4528.

The [Student Counseling Center](#) offers confidential services to students either for individual appointments or as part of groups. Initial appointments must be made in person in the Student Counseling Center, which is located in SSB 4.600, on the fourth floor of the Student Services Building. Their main number is 972-883-2575 and the 24/7 Crisis Hotline is 972-883-8255 (972-UTD-TALK).

The [Student Health Center \(SHC\)](#) provides primary and preventative medical care to currently enrolled students who have paid medical fees and are attending classes. Currently enrolled students can obtain a wide variety of services, such as physicals, diagnosis and treatment of acute illnesses and injuries, general medical problems, gynecological problems, treatment of stabilized chronic illnesses, allergy injections, limited immunizations, x-rays, and ultrasound. SHC staff of licensed medical providers is committed to keeping the UT Dallas community healthy and believes that health and wellness information complement the academic success of students. SHC is located on the fourth floor of the Student Services Building, SSB 4.700 and they can be reached by telephone, 972-883-2747, fax, 877-769-7514, or by [email](#).

The [Testing Center](#), run by the Education Technology Services, offers a 300-seat computer lab, providing UT Dallas students access to a comfortable and secure test environment for online/paper exams, quizzes, instructional testing, and assessments. The Testing Center is located in Room 11.175, the first floor of the Synergy Park North 2 (SP2) building and can be contacted by calling 972-883-2460 or by [email](#). If you experience issues taking an exam in eLearning, please contact the UTD [eLearning Helpdesk](#).

The [Office of Graduate Education Fellowship Services](#) offers workshops on fellowship and grant writing, including a Grant Writing Certificate program. Students applying for external funding can schedule appointments to find funding and to develop their applications. The Fellowship Office is located in FA 3.104C, on the second floor of the Founders West Annex. The office's phone number is 972-883-4568.

The [Office of Graduate Education Writing Services](#) offers workshops on writing as well as one-on-one appointments, writing groups, and writing retreats to help graduate students improve their writing skills. The Writing Services Office is located in FA 3.104, on the second floor of the Founders West Annex. Appointments can be made via [email](#).

University Resources

Additional university resources, "Resources for Study and Campus Life" are listed in the online [Undergraduate Catalog](#) and the [Graduate Catalog](#).

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